

What else to watch: *The Spy Who Came in from the Cold* (1965) ■ *The Conversation* (1974) ■ *Wings of Desire* (1987, pp.258–61) ■ *Nikolaikirche* (1995) ■ *Black Book* (2006) ■ *The White Ribbon* (2009, p.323)



couple's apartment building with his listening equipment connected to microphones hidden in the home's light switches and walls, Wiesler eavesdrops on the couple's phone calls, conversations, lovemaking, and arguments. Gradually, he begins to appreciate the basic decency and humanity of Georg and Christa-Maria. When he learns that Georg is being targeted not for any political disloyalty, but because

the Minister of Culture lusts after Christa-Maria and wants to eliminate Georg, Wiesler's idealism deserts him. "Is this what we signed up for?" he asks his amoral superior, Grubitz (Ulrich Tukur).

Georg, however, is indeed having politically disloyal thoughts. As he falls under suspicion for writing a subversive article about the country's suicide rate, and the government's callous indifference toward it, for a West German magazine, the Stasi blackmails Christa-Maria into betraying him. And this is where the movie resonated so strongly for many former East Germans. The regime functioned by making everyone complicit in a brutal system, using fear to compel ordinary people to betray their neighbors, colleagues, and families. It forced moral choices between career and love, safety

During an evening at the theater, Wiesler's boss, Lieutenant-Colonel Anton Grubitz, points out the target for Wiesler's surveillance.

and personal integrity. The movie underscores this psychological pressure and dread with its desolate depiction of East Berlin, a shadowy, nightmare city of invisible eyes and ears.

Redemption and fall

While *The Lives of Others* had a particular potency for German audiences, its success in winning the Oscar for Best Foreign Movie proved that its power traveled beyond borders. The venality of the Stasi was familiar to many who had felt the chill of repressive regimes, or who simply feared a surveillance state. And in the story of Georg and Christa-Maria the movie featured a classic tortured romance, with the sad-eyed secret policeman as its mute witness. ■

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You never know, from one moment to the next, what course any of the characters will choose.

A. O. Scott

The New York Times, 2007

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The movie was praised for its accuracy, except in one regard. Historians note there is no record of a Stasi agent ever having saved a target.

